

TPM Academy — Tech Setup

Last updated: 2026-05-01 (rev 2)

Practical setup guide for participants and facilitators. Cover pre-academy setup once; refer back week-by-week as new tools come into play.

Audience

- **Participants:** read sections 1–3 before Week 1. Skim section 4 (week-by-week additions) the Friday before each new week.
- **Facilitators:** verify section 5 (pre-flight checklist) before each week. Section 6 covers fallback procedures when tooling fails.

1. Hardware & connectivity (pre-academy)

Requirement	Minimum	Recommended
Laptop	Modern dual-core, 8 GB RAM, 256 GB	Quad-core+, 16 GB RAM
OS	macOS 12+, Windows 10+, Ubuntu 22.04+	Latest stable
Browser	Chrome / Edge / Firefox latest	Same
Internet	Reliable broadband	Wired or 5GHz Wi-Fi
Webcam + mic	Working for remote sessions	Headset preferred
Display	1 monitor, 1280×720+	1080p+; second monitor helpful

For remote cohorts: confirm video conferencing client installed (Zoom, Teams, or Meet — per academy delivery).

2. Accounts & access (pre-academy)

Confirm before Week 1 starts. Many of these need IT or admin time — start early.

2.1 Generative AI tool access

Every participant needs **at least two** of:

- **Claude** (Anthropic) — free tier acceptable for the academy; paid tier preferred for longer context
- **ChatGPT** (OpenAI) — free tier acceptable; Plus preferred
- **Gemini / Copilot / equivalent** — for cross-tool comparison on Week 1 Day 1

For Week 1 Day 1's "Same Question, Three Models" activity, the cohort collectively needs three different tools available. Coordinate so triads have coverage.

2.2 Skills / SkillIQ platform (pre- and post-assessments)

- Pre-assessment access: required before Week 1 (Product Management + Data Literacy)
- Post-assessment access: required for Week 8 Day 5
- Confirm participant logins work the week before academy begins

2.3 Azure DevOps (Week 7 only)

Each triad needs one of:

- **Live ADO project** with create-work-item permissions (preferred — sandbox if possible)
- **Sandbox / training ADO instance** provisioned by IT
- **Read-only ADO access** with paper-template fallback (last resort)

If live ADO isn't available by Week 7 Day 1, fall back to the **paper-template** version of Day 2's lab — see section 6.

2.4 Document tooling

Each triad needs a shared workspace for collaborative editing:

- **Confluence / SharePoint / Google Docs / Notion** — pick one and use it consistently
- The 5 sibling artifacts (PRD/TCD/TMD/SEP/DP) live here
- Version history is required

2.5 Diagramming (Week 4–5)

For C4 diagrams (Wk 4 Day 3) and sequence diagrams (Wk 5 Day 4):

- **Whiteboard + paper** is fully sufficient — phone photos serve as the artifact
- **Miro / Lucidchart / Excalidraw / Figma** if digital is preferred
- **Mermaid** in the team's wiki for inline-in-doc diagrams

Don't over-invest in tooling here; the diagrams are thinking aids, not deliverables.

2.6 Communication

- A **cohort channel** (Slack / Teams) for asynchronous Q&A and resource sharing
- A **triad channel** per triad for daily coordination
- An **instructor DM thread** for individual coaching

3. Installations (pre-academy)

Most academy tools are browser-based. Two local installs help:

3.1 Reveal.js decks (already provided)

The daily decks live in `week-XX/presentations/day-XX-*.html`. They render directly in any modern browser:

A screenshot of a dark-themed code editor showing a file path. The text is "File → Open → week-01/presentations/day-01-ai-fundamentals-prompting.html". The "File" and "Open" parts are in a lighter color, while the rest is in a standard monospace font.

```
File → Open → week-01/presentations/day-01-ai-fundamentals-prompting.html
```

No build step needed; Reveal.js loads from CDN. Press S for speaker notes / clock.

3.2 Markdown editor (recommended)

For authoring PRDs, TCDs, etc., a markdown editor with live preview is helpful:

- **Obsidian** (free) — strong cross-doc linking

- **VS Code** + Markdown Preview Enhanced
- **Typora** (paid) — minimal interface

The labs reference markdown templates throughout; a comfortable editor pays off across all 8 weeks.

4. Week-by-week additions

Week 1 — Customer-Centric Foundations

- All AI tools confirmed and working
- Persona Validation Canvas, Pain-Point Severity Matrix, Problem Statement Template (printed or digital — see lab packets)

Week 2 — Strategic Design & Metrics

- Spreadsheet for Tier Sheet (Excel / Google Sheets / Numbers)
- Whiteboard or A2 paper for Journey Map Canvas (Day 5)

Week 3 — Requirements Engineering & Mini-Capstone

- **AI tools off** for the week — honor system. Disable AI features in your editor.
- Markdown editor for PRD drafting
- Print or share digitally: PRD template (1 per triad)

Week 4 — Technical Architecture & Constraints

- AI tools restored
- Whiteboard / Miro / Lucidchart for C4 diagrams (Day 3)
- STRIDE Card handout (Day 2)

Week 5 — Technical Infrastructure & Modeling

- AI tools, with validation discipline
- Diagramming tool for sequence diagrams (Day 4)
- Reference cards for HTTP status codes, REST methods (printed or bookmarked)

Week 6 — Stakeholder Alignment & Negotiation

- Power × Interest grid (paper or whiteboard)
- Stakeholder persona scripts (Day 5 simulation handouts) — instructor prepares ahead
- Surprise objection sets (Day 5) — instructor prepares ahead

Week 7 — Agile Delivery & ADO Mastery

- **ADO access confirmed** (see 2.3 above)

- ADO Cheat Sheet handout (Day 2)
- VSM Canvas — large paper or whiteboard (Day 4)

Week 8 — AI Spec Development & Capstone

- AI tools, with validation discipline
- Capstone subject inputs gathered before Day 1 (interviews / data / docs — per triad)
- Presentation projector / screen sharing for Friday
- Post-assessment access confirmed (Skills / SkillIQ)

5. Facilitator pre-flight checklist (per week)

Run this checklist the **Friday before each week begins**:

- ☐ All participants have access to required tools (cross-check section 4)
- ☐ Print or digitally share the lab packet for Monday
- ☐ Pre-print handouts called out in each day's Facilitator pre-flight checklist
- ☐ Confirm any Week-specific instructor-prepared materials (Wk 6 stakeholder personas, Wk 7 ADO sandbox, etc.)
- ☐ Verify cohort channel and triad channels are live
- ☐ Verify the deck file for each day opens correctly in browser

For **Week 7 specifically**: test ADO access with a sample work item by Friday Week 6. Don't discover ADO issues at 09:00 Monday.

For **Week 8 specifically**: confirm the post-assessment platform is active and participants can log in by Thursday Week 7.

6. Fallback procedures

When tools fail, the academy continues. Don't let tooling block learning.

If this fails	Do this
AI tool down for one cohort	Pair-up with a triad whose tool works; document as a constraint in the provenance log
All AI tools down	Day's AI activity becomes a paper exercise : triads write the prompt, predict the output, then review when AI returns
ADO unavailable Week 7	Run Day 2 as " ADO concepts on paper " — same 4-level hierarchy, same field discipline, captured in markdown. Coverage similar; hands-on practice is the loss.
Whiteboard / projector fails	Triads work on paper; phone photos are the artifact
Document workspace down	Local markdown files; sync when service returns
Pre/post-assessment platform down	Run paper version of the same instruments; submit when platform returns

The academy's content is the muscle, not the tool. Tooling failures are an inconvenience, not a blocker.

7. Common setup issues

Issue	Fix
AI tool rate-limits during heavy use	Distribute prompts across triad members' accounts; stagger API-heavy activities
ADO permission errors	IT ticket; meanwhile use sandbox or paper
Reveal.js deck won't render	Try a different browser; confirm internet for CDN; check console for blocked scripts
Markdown editor doesn't show tables	Switch to a CommonMark-compliant editor; preview in a browser
Network can't reach Slack/Teams	Triad channels via SMS / personal email as fallback

8. Pre-academy participant onboarding email (template)

Adapt and send 1 week before academy start:

Subject: TPM Academy – Setup Steps Before [Date]

Welcome. Before academy begins on [date], please confirm:

1. Hardware: laptop with webcam, modern browser, reliable internet
2. AI tools: at least two of Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini/Copilot – confirmed working
3. Pre-assessments: Product Management + Data Literacy submitted on the Skills platform [link]
4. Cohort channel: you've joined [Slack/Teams workspace link]
5. Pre-work (~3.5 hrs): complete the linked self-paced modules:
 - Exploring PM Philosophies and Frameworks [link]
 - Agile Methodologies primer [link]
 - Getting Started on Prompt Engineering [link]

Please reply with any access issues by [3 days before start].

Looking forward to Monday.

9. Resources

- Course README: `README.md`
- Source outline: `tools/outline.pdf`
- Daily decks: `week-XX/presentations/day-XX-*.html`
- Lab packets: `week-XX/labs/day-XX-*.md`
- Week overviews: `week-XX/labs/README.md`